

Notes on the parables of Jesus

The word “parable” or any form of it appears:

Book	Occurrences	Verses	Chapters
Matthew	17	16	5
Mark	12	11	5
Luke	17	17	11
John	1	1	1
	47	45	22

Matthew and Mark both include the following phrases but Luke does not:

Matthew 13:34 All these things spake Jesus unto the multitude in parables; and without a parable spake he not unto them:	Mark 4:34 But without a parable spake he not unto them ^("a great multitude" v1) ; and when they were alone, he expounded all things to his disciples.
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Keep in mind that both of those rules only apply contextually and they are not universally applicable. Proof of that is found elsewhere when Jesus speaks to the Pharisees or the multitude and it is not in parables (Mat 23:13-33, John 8, etc).

The following table includes only parables that are explicitly or implicitly called a parable. It does not include verses, phrases, figures of speech, or even what appears to be a parable unless it is explicitly or implicitly called a parable in Scripture. An explicit parable is one that is called a parable in Scripture.

An implicit parable is a parallel passage to an explicit parable. There are a total of 9 parables that are not explicitly called parables in their context but they are implicitly a parable due to being reasonably similar to an explicitly named parable.

Matthew	Mark	Luke
#15-#18 (implicit) Mat 12:25-37 Has other phrases in the same paragraph that may be identified as parables but they are not called parables anywhere in Scripture: • The good & corrupt tree and their fruit • The good & evil treasure of the heart	#15-#18 (explicit) Mar 3:23-29 (v23 “parables”) 1. Satan divided against himself 2. A kingdom divided against itself 3. A house divided against itself 4. The binding and spoiling of the strong man	#15-#18 (implicit) Luk 11:17-26 Has another phrase that may be identified as a parable but it is not called a parable anywhere in Scripture: • The unclean spirit
#1 The Sower (explicit) Mat 13:3-8, 19-23	#1 The Sower (explicit) Mar 4:2-8, 14-20	#1 The Sower (explicit) Luk 8:5-8, 11-15
#2 The Wheat & the Tares (explicit) Mat 13:24-30, 37-42		
#3 The Mustard Seed (explicit) Mat 13:31,32	#3 The Mustard Seed (explicit; Mar 4:33) Mar 4:30-32	#3 The Mustard Seed (implicit) Luk 13:18,19
#4 Leaven (explicit) Mat 13:33		#4 Leaven (implicit) Luk 13:20,21
#5 Hid Treasure (explicit; Mat 13:53) Mat 13:44		
#6 A Pearl of Great Price (explicit; Mat 13:53) Mat 13:45,46		
#7 Net in the Sea (explicit; Mat 13:53) Mat 13:47-50		

#8 What Defileth a Man (explicit & implicit) Mat 15:10-20 Peter asks about “this parable” but there are 3 potential phrases in this paragraph (the latter two are likely a response to His disciples question in v12): 1. #8 What defiles a man ◦ Explicitly a parable because of what Peter asks. Implicitly a parable because of Mar 7:14,15. 2. Every plant that shall be rooted up 3. #9 The blind leading the blind ◦ Implicitly a parable because of Luk 6:39.	#8 What Defileth a Man (explicit) Mar 7:14,15 The disciples asked “concerning the parable” when they were away from the people v17. The same explanation is given as in Mat 15:17-20.	#9 The Blind Leading the Blind (explicit) Luk 6:39 Has other phrases in the same paragraph that may be identified as parables but they are not explicitly called parables anywhere in Scripture: • The mote and the beam • The good & evil treasure of the heart (similar to Mat 12:35) • Building on the rock or the earth (similar to Mat 7:24-27 except “sand”)
#10 Two Sons (explicit; Mat 21:33a “hear another parable”) Mat 21:28-32		
#11 The Stone Which the Builders Rejected (explicit) Mat 21:33-44	#11 The Stone Which the Builders Rejected (explicit) Mar 12:1-11	#11 The Stone Which the Builders Rejected (explicit) Luk 20:9-18
#12 Wedding for the King’s Son (explicit; v1 “parables”) Mat 22:1-13		
#13 Many Are Called, Few Are Chosen (explicit; v1 “parables”) Mat 22:14 Note: A very similar phrase appears at the end of Mat 20:1-16 which is not explicitly called a parable; the context at the end of Mat 19 is Jesus speaking to His disciples).		
#14 The Fig Tree (explicit) Mat 24:32,33	#14 The Fig Tree (explicit) Mar 13:28,29	#14 The Fig Tree and All the Trees (explicit) Luk 21:29-31

#19 The Candle (implicit) Mat 5:14-16 v14, 16 are not in Mar or Luk	#19 The Candle (explicit; Mar 4:33) Mar 4:21,22	#19 The Candle (implicit) Luk 8:16,17 (Luk 12:2,3) Has other phrases similar to Mat 6:22,23 that could be identified as as a parable but are not explicitly called one anywhere in Scripture: The light of the body is the eye
Has the latter part of #21 The Good Hearer but lacks the first part about hearing (instead, has what appears to be a parable but is not ever called one) Mat 13:12	#21 The Good Hearer (explicit; Mar 4:33) Mar 4:24,25 Note: has an extra phrase: <i>"with what measure ye mete, it shall be measured to you: and unto you that hear shall more be given."</i>	#21 The Good Hearer (implicit) Luke 8:18 Note: has slightly different wording but it doesn't appear to be different enough to be an entirely different parable.
	#22 The Blade, Ear, and Corn (explicit; Mark 4:33) Mark 4:26-29	
#22 Garment/Wine Bottles (implicit; all one parable because of Luk 5:36a) Mat 9:16 Mat 9:17	#22 Mar 2:21,22 (implicit; all one parable because of Luk 5:36a)	#22 Garment/Wine Bottles (explicit; all one parable because of Luk 5:36a) Luk 5:36 Luk 5:37-38 Luk 5:39
		#23 The Foolish Rich Man (explicit) Luk 12:16-21
#24 The Faithful Steward (implicit) Mat 24:45-51		#24 The Faithful & Wise Steward/Servant (explicit; Peter calls one of the 3 figurative phrases in the previous paragraph v22-40 a parable and based on Jesus' response it was the one immediately preceding Peter's question) Luk 12:36-40 Other figurative phrases in Luk 12:22-40 that Peter could have been referring to: - The Ravens - The Lilies/grass - Bags/treasure - Girded loins/Lights burning
		#25 The Unfruitful Fig Tree (explicit) Luk 13:6-9

Mat 23:12 Has a very similar phrase to the end of #26 (v11) but does not contain the preceding parable.		#26 Where to Sit at a Wedding (explicit) Luk 14:7-11 Luk 14:12-14 (not a parable)
#27 Mat 18:12,13 (implicit; does not have The Lost Coin)		#27 The 99 & 1 sheep and The Lost Coin (explicit; these are both part of the same paragraph that begins with “And he spake this parable” singular) Luk 15:3-7 Luk 15:8-10
		#28 The Unjust Judge (explicit) Luk 18:1-8
		#29 The Pharisee & the Publican (explicit) Luk 18:9-14 Note: this one ends almost exactly the same as #26 (the only difference being “every one/whosoever”)
Mat 25:14-30 Similar to #30 The Nobleman but not close enough to be the same parable.		#30 The Nobleman (explicit) Luk 19:11-27 Note: v26 is almost the same as #21 The Good Hearer
John		
#31 The Good Shepherd (explicit) John 10:1-16		

Notes:

- **Mat 20:1-16** (The householder that went out early in the morning to hire labourers for his vineyard) is not ever explicitly called a parable. It does begin with “**For the kingdom of heaven is like**” and it does end with a verse that is explicitly called a parable elsewhere (v**16**, #**13** Many Are Called, Few Are Chosen, **Mat 22:14**). But, because it is not an explicit or implicit parable it was not counted in this list.
- **Mat 13:52** “*Then said he unto them, **Therefore every scribe which is instructed unto the kingdom of heaven is like unto a man that is an householder, which bringeth forth out of his treasure things new and old.***” follows the same pattern as other parables but it is not counted for the same reason (it is not ever explicitly or implicitly called a parable).
- **Mat 11:16-19** (not included although it is a figurative comparison)
- **Mat 25:14-30** “The Unprofitable Servant” looks a lot like a parable but it is not ever called one.
- **Luke 14:27** is obviously figurative, but it is not ever called a parable.
 - Likewise **Mat 5:13**, **Mar 9:50**, & **Luke 14:34**.
- Much of Jesus’ speech is rife with figurative speech and comparisons that could be considered parables (more than 40 before even getting to The Sower in Matthew alone). But, again, if it isn’t explicitly or implicitly called a parable it is not counted as one in this list.
- There are three Strong’s numbers associated with the word “parable” in the Bible. Here they are listed with the first time each one appears and with all the words they are translated to:
 - H4912 (**Num 23:7**) - מָשָׁל (mâshâl | maw-shawl') – byword, like, parable, proverb
 - G3850 (**Mat 13:3**) - παραβολή (parabolé | par-ab-ol-ay') – comparison, figure, parable, proverb
 - G3942 (**Joh 10:6**) - παροιμία (paroimía | par-oy-mee'-ah) – parable, proverb

Grand total unique parables: 31

Grand total all parables: 50